

Microtus arvalis

Common vole



Length 3½–4¾ in (9–12 cm)

Tail 1¼–1¾ in (3–4.5 cm)

Weight 1⅙–1½ oz (20–45 g)

Location W. Europe to W. and C. Asia

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



This medium-sized vole is one of the most numerous rodents in grassy and farmland habitats. It has short fur, gray-brown or sandy on the back changing to gray underneath, a blunt snout, small eyes and ears, stocky body, and short, furred tail. It digs burrows to make nest chambers and food stores, and eats chiefly green plant parts such as grass blades. In winter, it may take refuge in a barn or haystack, and gnaw soft bark.

Ondatra zibethicus

Muskrat



Length 10–14 in (25–35 cm)

Tail 8–10 in (20–25 cm)

Weight 1¼–4½ lb (0.6–2 kg)

Location North America

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



The muskrat usually lives in a group of up to 10, digging tunnels in the bank or building a beaverlike home (lodge) from mud, plant stems, and twigs. It eats reeds and other water plants, and occasionally hunts for crayfish, frogs, fish, and mollusks. The female builds a nest in a dry tunnel chamber or lodge platform, where the litter of 1–3 young are born. Musk secretions are used, with droppings and urine, to mark out territories.



fine underfur with long, coarse guard hairs

MUSKY SMELL
The muskrat is named after the musky-smelling secretions from glands around its genital and anal region. The glands are especially prominent in males and enlarge at breeding time.

Myodes glareolus

Bank vole



Length 2¾–5¼ in (7–13.5 cm)

Tail 1½–2½ in (3.5–6.5 cm)

Weight ⅞–1¼ oz (12–35 g)

Location W. Europe to N. Asia

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



Typically blunt-headed, the bank vole's upperparts vary from yellowish to reddish or brown, with gray flanks, gray-white rump, white feet, and a slightly bushy-tipped tail. The species also varies greatly in size, being twice as long and 3 times as heavy in some regions compared to others. The bank vole is very adaptable, nesting in burrows, thickets, and tree stumps, and eating a huge range of foods, from fungi and mosses to seeds, buds, insects, and birds' eggs.



Arvicola amphibius

Eurasian water vole



Length 4¾–9 in (12–23 cm)

Tail 2¾–4¾ in (7–11 cm)

Weight 2½–11 oz (60–300 g)

Location W. Europe to W. and N. Asia

Social unit Individual/Pair

Status Least concern



Water voles that mainly burrow in meadows and woods are almost half the size of those that live near rivers, lakes, and marshes. Both types eat plant foods and have thick fur, which is gray, brown, or black on the upperparts and dark gray to white below. The rounded tail is half the body length. This vole is threatened by pollution, loss of habitat, and an introduced predator, mink.

Lemmus sibiricus

Brown lemming



Length 4¾–6 in (12–15 cm)

Tail ¾–½ in (1–1.5 cm)

Weight 1½–5½ oz (45–150 g)

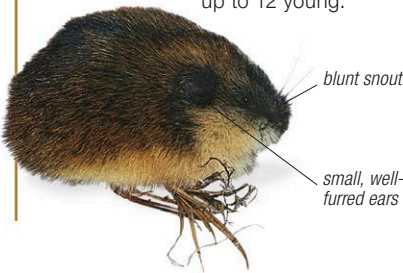
Location N. Asia

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



The brown lemming lives in large colonies, breeds prolifically, and makes small-scale seasonal migrations between high, shrubby grassland and moors, and sheltered lowlands for winter. Its migrations are much less spectacular than those of the Norway lemming (*Lemmus lemmus*), which is sometimes driven by instinct to try to swim rivers or scramble down cliffs. The brown lemming eats mosses, sedges, herbs, and soft twigs, and sometimes birds' eggs. The female builds a nest from grass and her own fur and, after a gestation period of 18 days, produces up to 12 young.



Lagurus lagurus

Steppe vole



Length 3¼–4¾ in (8–12 cm)

Tail ⅞–¾ in (0.7–2 cm)

Weight ⅞–1¼ oz (25–35 g)

Location E. Europe to E. Asia

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



Long, waterproof fur, even covering feet and ears, keeps the steppe vole warm in the cold north Asian steppes. It has a black stripe along the middle of its pale gray or cinnamon back, and pale underparts. Burrows up to 12 in (30 cm) deep give temporary shelter, while more permanent ones—3 times as deep—house grass-lined nests. There are 5 litters per year of up to 12 young.

